



Illinois

Democratic contender for Congress indicted over Chicago ICE protests

Progressive Palestinian American candidate Kat Abughazaleh, 26, decries 'gross attempt at silencing dissent'

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Kat Abughazaleh, a progressive candidate for Congress, has been indicted on federal charges related to her participation in protests outside an ICE processing facility near [Chicago](#) in September.

The [indictment](#), filed last week, alleges that the 26-year old Palestinian American candidate and five other individuals “physically hindered and impeded” a federal agent who was “forced to drive at an extremely slow rate of speed to avoid injuring any of the conspirators”.

Abughazaleh, who is [running for](#) Illinois’s ninth congressional district to replace the outgoing Democrat Jan Schakowsky, was charged with conspiracy to forcibly impede or injure a federal agent, and assaulting or impeding the agent while they were performing official duties.

According to the indictment, the group “conspired with one another and others, known and unknown, to prevent by force, intimidation, and threat, Agent A, a United States law enforcement officer, from discharging the duties of his office”.

It alleged that Abughazaleh, along with the other individuals, “banged aggressively” on the agent’s vehicle, “crowded together in the front and side” of the vehicle and “pushed against the vehicle to hinder and impede its movement”.

According to the indictment, the group etched the word “pig” on to the vehicle and broke a side mirror and a rear windshield wiper. It also alleged that Abughazaleh specifically “joined the crowd at the front of the government vehicle, and with her hands on the hood braced her body and hands against the vehicle while remaining directly in the path of the vehicle, hindering and impeding” the agent.

Following the indictment, Abughazaleh, who is known for her large [social media platform](#) on which she frequently criticizes Donald Trump’s immigration crackdowns, called the indictment “political prosecution”.

“This is a ... gross attempt at silencing dissent, a right protected under the first amendment. This case is yet another attempt by the [Trump administration](#) to criminalize protest and punish those who dare to speak up. That’s why I’m going to

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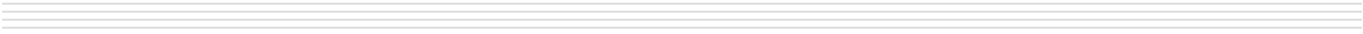
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slide towards fascism and I’m not going to give up now,” she continued.

The indictment comes as the Trump administration **ramps up** federal immigration raids across numerous progressive cities including Chicago - a move which has been harshly **criticized** by local and state leaders.

The raids have drawn widespread opposition from the public, congressional Democratic **lawmakers** and civil rights groups, with the ACLU **describing** them as a “build out of a national paramilitary policing force that could be used to ... consolidate President Donald Trump’s power”.



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